

Altered States

An altered state of consciousness is any condition that differs significantly from our normal state of consciousness (see pp.162–163). It is almost always temporary and always reversible.

Types of altered states

Altered states can be grouped into categories based on how they are induced. However, all altered states disrupt brain function in some way.

Spontaneous

Spontaneously induced altered states include drowsiness, daydreaming, near-death experiences, and the state of consciousness that happens just before you fall asleep (known as a hypnagogic state).

Psychological

An altered state can be induced through certain cultural or religious practices, such as meditation or trances brought on through dancing or drumming. Other examples are sensory deprivation and hypnosis.

Physical and physiological

Extreme environmental conditions, such as high altitudes or weaker gravity in space, can induce altered states, as can extended fasting and breath manipulation.

Disease-induced

Disease and illness can alter the conscious experience to different degrees. Examples include psychotic disorders such as schizophrenia (see p.211), as well as epileptic seizures and coma.

Pharmacological

Psychoactive (mind-altering) drugs, such as alcohol, cannabis, or opioids, disrupt how the brain's neurotransmitters function, altering the user's awareness and consciousness levels.

IS A NEAR-DEATH EXPERIENCE AN ALTERED STATE?

This is highly debated, but those who have had such experiences describe elements, such as a sense of timelessness, common to other altered states.

What is an altered state?

When we are in a normal state of consciousness, we are aware of external stimuli (such as our surroundings) and internal events (such as our thoughts). However, the brain can produce a much wider range of conscious experiences, including altered states. Whenever we enter an altered state, our brain patterns change. This disruption in brain function can be caused in different ways, including changes in blood flow and oxygen to the brain or interference with neurotransmitter function.